



The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory (JCRT)

. |

The Word of Freud: Our God Is Logos

Robert Metcalf

Metcalf - The Word of Freud - JCRT 3.2
 Robert Metcalf
 University of Colorado at Denver

Religions owe their compulsive power to the return of the repressed; they are reawakened memories of very ancient, forgotten, highly emotional episodes of human history. I have already said this in Totem and Taboo; I express it now in the formula: the strength of religion lies not in its material, but in its historical truth.

'Freud to Lou Andreas-Salomé', January 6, 1935¹

This is a strange book." So said T. S. Eliot of Freud's *The Future of an Illusion* when it appeared in English translation, and this assessment is as apt today as it was then.² It is, indeed, a strange and disturbing book, at once brilliant and opaque, honest yet intellectually frustrating. However, what upset Eliot about the book—namely, its alleged failure to define certain key concepts—seems minor in comparison to what troubles us about the book today: for example, its rather unnuanced and reductive approach to what Freud calls religious "ideas" [*Vorstellungen*], as well as its myopically positivistic view of science as a simple alternative to religious ideas.³ But there are good reasons to devote careful attention to Freud's polemic of 1927, not least of all because we have inherited Freud's problematic: a world riveted by clashing religious cultures, with no obvious recourse or opportunity for reconciliation.⁴ In a year that began with the American President proclaiming that "we are guided by a power larger than ourselves who created us equal in His image,"⁵ and ended with Americans at war in Afghanistan to subdue Islamic fundamentalists, we find ourselves asking Freud's question as to the future of religious culture—whether or not we interpret this as the future of an *illusion*.

> It is in keeping with the course of human development that external coercion gradually becomes internal. The ego is a most precious cultural asset in the psychological field. Those in whom it has taken place

To speak of "morality," as Freud does here, is to express in popular terms what psychoanalysis is. As a product of this process, he invokes a connection in German between making one's life "bearable"

> The father himself constitutes a danger for the child, perhaps because of its earlier relationship

¹See Sigmund Freud and Lou Andreas-Salomé, *Letters*, edited by Ernst Pfeiffer, New York: Basic Books, 1960, pp. 204-5. Freud explicates this point a few years later in *Moses and Monotheism*: "We too believe that the pious solution contains the truth—but the *historical* truth and not the *material* truth... That is to say, we do not believe that there is a single great god today, but that in primeval times there was a single person who was bound to appear huge at that time and who afterwards returned in men's memory elevated to divinity" (SE XXIII, p. 129). The echo here of Nietzsche's second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals* is unmistakable.

²See T.S. Eliot, "The Future of an Illusion, by Sigmund Freud," originally published in *Criterion*, VIII, Vol. 3, 1929, pp. 350-53, reprinted in Sigmund Freud, *Critical Assessments*, Vol. III, edited by Lawrence Spurling, London and New York: Routledge, 1989.

³There have been numerous critics to heap abuse on Freud for these defects, as Peter Gay has catalogued in *A Godless Jew: Freud, Atheism and the Making of Psychoanalysis*, New Haven and London: Yale Univ. Press, 1987. Whatever we think of these various criticisms, we can surely understand Gay's lament that Freud's views of religion lack the subtlety he lavished on analyzing neuroses, p. 12.

⁴Recently this contemporary situation has been analyzed as a "clash of civilizations" in Samuel P. Huntington's *The Clash of Civilizations and the Remaking of World Order*, New York: Simon & Schuster, 1998.

⁵George W. Bush's inaugural address to the nation, January 20, 2001.

In this way, Freud concludes that religious ideas have arisen from the need common to all cultural achievements: the necessity of providing “defence” against the crushingly superior force of nature (XXI, 21; XIV, 343). By helping the individual to achieve psychical mastery [*Bewältigung*], if not physical control, over the vulnerability of his situation, these ideas serve to rob nature of at least some of her power. Thus, the God or gods who are fashioned in this process are given a three-fold task that is identical to that of cultural achievements in general: to exorcize the terrors of nature, to reconcile men to the cruelty of fate, particularly as it is shown in death, and to compensate them for the sufferings and privations that communal life has imposed on them (XXI, 18; XIV, 339). Notice how nothing in this account necessitates the conclusion that Freud draws—namely, that the relationship between religion and culture must be fundamentally altered. Indeed, Freud acknowledges that apologists of religion could use the psychological grounding [*Begründung*] that psychoanalysis offers to “give full value to the affective significance of religious doctrines” (XXI, 37; XIV, 360).⁶ For Freud, psychoanalysis is nothing but a method of research, an “impartial [*parteiloses*] instrument, like infinitesimal calculus” (XXI, 36; XIV, 360), and thus underdetermines any effort, like Freud’s in *The Future of an Illusion*, to “take sides” [*Parteinehmen*] (cf. XXI, 32; XIV, 355). As Freud will reiterate in his treatment of the “Question of a *Weltanschauung*” in the *New Introductory Lectures on Psychoanalysis*, psychoanalysis is unable to create a *Weltanschauung* of its own, but adheres to the scientific approach (XXII, 158, 181; XV, 170-171, 197).⁷

> I am reminded of one of my children who was distinguished at an early age by a peculiarly man-of-factness. When the children were being told a fairy tale and were listening to it with rapt

Given his approach, we should not be surprised to read Freud's argument that criticism has what fulfillment—indeed, fulfillment of the oldest, strongest and most urgent wishes of mankind (XXI,

> Scientific work is the only road which can lead us to a knowledge of reality outside ourselves (XXI, 32; XIV, 354)

But Freud goes further than this. Addressing the right or justification \[_Recht_\] one has for

> Critics persist in describing as “deeply religious” anyone who admits to a sense of man's inferiority (XXI, 32; XIV, 355)

In this passage we should notice the way in which Freud endorses the particular acknowledgment of the limitation \[_Triebeinschränkung_\] whatsoever (ibid).

The case is similar to what happens when we tell a child that new-born babies are brought by the stork. Here, too, we are telling the truth in symbolic clothing, for we know what the large bird signifies. But the child does not know it. He hears only the distorted part of what we say, and feels that he has been deceived; and we know how often his distrust of grown-ups and contrariness [*Widersetzlichkeit*] actually take their start from this impression. We have become convinced that it is better to avoid such symbolic disguisings of the truth in what we tell children and not to withhold from

⁶See, for example, Erich Fromm’s *Psychoanalysis and Religion*, New Haven and London: Yale Univ. Press, 1950, for a psychoanalytic defense of what he calls “humanistic religion” as opposed to “authoritarian” religion.

⁷Freud’s understanding of the term, “*Weltanschauung*,” is itself illuminating: “In my opinion, then, a *Weltanschauung* is an intellectual construction which solves all the problems of our existence uniformly on the basis of one overriding hypothesis, which, accordingly, leaves no question unanswered and in which everything that interests us finds its fixed place” (XXII, 158; XV, 170-171).

them a knowledge of the true state of affairs commensurate with their intellectual level.
(XXI, 44-5; XIV, 368)

> These reformations \[_Umbildungen_\] of religious doctrine, which you have condemned as half measures and compromises, make it possible to avoid the cleft between the uneducated masses and

Freud's interlocutor takes himself to have shown that the attempt to radically alter the rela

> I will moderate my zeal and admit the possibility that I, too, am chasing an illusion. Perhaps
2)

Asking hypothetically whether infantilism is destined to be overcome \[_der Infantilismus ist
74).

> The primacy of the intellect lies, it is true, in a distant, distant future, but probably no seeking than I and those on my side. You would have the state of bliss begin directly after death
4; XIV, 377-78).

Here Freud provides an important qualification of his earlier distinction between the essence of the than-almighty God can offer us (XXI, 54-5; XIV, 378-79). And yet it is clear that if the irrel

> It is well known that at an earlier date \[religion\] comprised everything that played an important role contained to an unparalleled degree which, although it has been profoundly shaken, persists to

However, at the very least, Freud's account of "the advance in spirituality/intellectuality \[and] seeking."[^21] If the "dematerialized God" of Moses signifies, in Freud's words, "a triumph of the ego" (XXI, 15; XVI, 220-222)'indeed, to a dynamic tradition of such changes, culminating perhaps in the G

> That religion also brought the Jews a far grander conception of God, or, as we might put it, the ego's esteem \[_Selbstgef'hl_\] is increased, that he is made proud \[_stolz zu machen_\]'so that he is
15; XVI, 219-222)[^24]

To explain why this advance in intellectuality, and subordination of sensuality, should raise such a regard, Freud analyzes it as a substitutive satisfaction within the libidinal economy. Although the ego as the child once acted toward his or her parents: "Just as in childhood, the ego is appalled by the sacrifice of an instinctual renunciation, it expects to be rewarded by receiving more love" (XXI, 225). But though the ego operates here according to the childhood pattern, the narcissistic character of the "seeking" on a deeper level, as uncovered by psychoanalysis.

> Thus we are faced by the phenomenon that in the course of the development of humanity sensual

This narcissistic aetiology of intellectual pursuits is not confined to the argument of the "Moses" as sufficient \[_der eher selbstgen'gsame Narzi'tische_\], will seek his main satisfactions in his intellectual substitutes (XXI, 4; XIV, 442). To be sure, Freud's discovery of narcissism within intellectual pursuits is fascinating, but it substitutes.

> Long ago \[man\] formed an ideal conception of omnipotence and omniscience which he embodied in his gods (XXI, 2; XIV, 450-451)

Here we need not appeal to psychoanalysis for an account of how an individual's self-regard is affected by his culture's conception of God. For the manifest content of this passage technological culture's so much so, in fact, that he admits to the consolation provided by man's

Notes

Den Himmel 'berlassen wir Den Engeln und den Spatzen. (Heaven we leave to the angels and the sparrows) Citations from Freud will refer first to the *Standard Edition's* English translation by James Strachey, volume and page number, then to the German of Freud's *Gesammelte Werke*, volume and page number. Thus, here I cite Freud's *Future of an Illusion* (XXI, 50; XIV, 374). * * *

Robert Metcalf received his doctorate from Penn State University and teaches philosophy at the University of Colorado at Denver. His research and teaching span ancient Greek philosophy, ethics, social and political philosophy, and the history of philosophy.

' 2002 Robert Metcalf. All rights reserved.
Updated 07/28/21.
jcrt.org/archives/03.2/metcalf
